

UNIFIED RESPONSE TO VIOLENT INCIDENTS (URVI)

Framework for Los Angeles County Operational Guidelines

Prepared by the URVI Guidelines Committee

Los Angeles County Public Safety Agencies

Version 1.0 | Effective: [DATE]

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1. EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The Unified Response to Violent Incidents (URVI) framework establishes a coordinated, multi-agency approach for Los Angeles County's response to active violence emergencies. URVI ensures that law enforcement, fire services, and emergency medical services (EMS) operate as a single cohesive force from the first moments of a crisis through recovery initiation.

This framework is a recommended guideline for all Los Angeles County public safety agencies. It does not supersede individual agency policies on use of force, tactical decisions, or specific departmental procedures. Instead, it provides the coordination architecture that enables agencies to work together effectively when violence strikes.

1.1 Preamble

The leader's intent of the URVI Framework is to support immediate, coordinated action during violent incidents. The framework is designed to help law enforcement, fire, and EMS resources operate from the earliest moments of a crisis with shared objectives: establish command, stop the threat, protect life, and begin lifesaving rescue operations as soon as conditions allow.

Responders should establish command immediately, including when operating in a mobile capacity, and transition to Unified Command as early as conditions and resources allow. Unified Command, common terminology, and coordinated communications remain essential to URVI operations; however, the absence of ideal coordination should not delay action when lives are at risk.

Cross-discipline integration is essential, but engagement should not be paused due to lack of staffing on either side. Responders should not delay downrange engagement because integration requirements have not been fully met. The imperative to save lives overrides the ideal of perfect coordination. Responders should adapt, act with available resources, and continue building coordination as the incident evolves.

This framework supports action over inaction, disciplined initiative, and coordinated decision-making while preserving responder safety and each agency's policies, authorities, and responsibilities.

1.2 Vision and Objectives

URVI envisions every violent emergency in Los Angeles County met with a seamless, collaborative response—no silos, no fragmented efforts, only a unified front focused on neutralizing threats and saving lives. The framework establishes five core objectives:

- **Establish Command from the Outset:** Establish Mobile Command upon arrival and transition to Unified Command as early as possible so all agencies share leadership and common objectives from the start.
- **Rapid Threat Neutralization:** Empower first responders to take immediate action to stop the threat, shortening the duration of violence.
- **Swift Victim Care and Evacuation:** Deploy integrated Rescue Task Forces (RTFs) quickly into cleared areas to treat and evacuate injured victims.
- **Interoperable Communication:** Use common terminology, interoperable radios, and coordinated tactics across all agencies.
- **Continuous Joint Preparedness:** Conduct regular multi-agency training and exercises to build interagency trust and operational readiness.

1.3 Target Audience

This document is intended for the entire Los Angeles County public safety community: law enforcement officers, firefighters, paramedics, EMTs, incident commanders, field supervisors, and dispatch centers. Personnel involved in planning, leading, or participating in the response to violent incidents are part of the target audience.

1.4 The Los Angeles County Operational Environment

Los Angeles County's public safety landscape demands a tailored approach to unified response. The county spans a population of over 10 million people and includes dozens of separate police and fire agencies. This patchwork of jurisdictions means that any significant violent incident will likely draw responders from multiple organizations with distinct protocols, radio systems, and command structures.

A pursuit or active shooter can easily cross city boundaries, requiring instant cooperation between municipal police, county deputies, and various fire/EMS teams. Los Angeles also hosts large-scale events that involve unified planning among police, fire, EMS, and federal partners. The region's dense urban landscape introduces additional complexity: high-rise buildings, heavy traffic, large crowds, and

sprawling venues all shape how perimeters are established, how zones are managed, and how resources are repositioned.

1.5 Alignment with National Doctrine

URVI is grounded in FIREScope 701, the National Incident Management System (NIMS) and the Incident Command System (ICS), ensuring all roles, terminology, and structures are nationally standardized. URVI operationalizes national doctrine for the specific realities of Los Angeles County.

1.6 Scope of Covered Incidents

The framework covers violent incident types requiring unified response, including active assailant attacks (for example, shooters, mass stabbings, and vehicle rammings), mass casualty terrorist attacks (including bombings and coordinated attacks), civil unrest and riots involving violence, armed barricades, and hostage situations. This list is not all-inclusive, and there may be other violent incidents requiring force protection escorts by law enforcement. Purely accidental events or natural disasters are outside the scope unless compounded by deliberate violent acts.

1.7 Consequences of Breaking from Doctrine

Straying from ICS, NIMS, or Unified Command during a high-risk violent incident can have severe consequences. Without unified command, agencies may pursue conflicting objectives, critical information may be missed, and responders may be placed in unnecessary danger. Lack of accountability leads to freelancing, overlapping efforts, and areas of the incident left unchecked. A fractured command structure wastes precious time and directly translates to slower threat neutralization and delayed victim treatment. Adherence to doctrine is essential.

The following section identifies the specific national standards—NIMS, ICS, and NFPA 3000—that form the doctrinal foundation upon which URVI is built.

2. NATIONAL DOCTRINE FOUNDATION

2.1 Core NIMS Principles

Several NIMS concepts are especially relevant for URVI response:

- **Common Terminology:** All responders use plain language and shared definitions for key terms. No agency-specific codes during URVI events.
- **Unified Command:** When multiple agencies are involved, leaders form one team to set objectives and priorities together.
- **Chain of Command and Unity of Command:** Every responder knows exactly who they report to under the incident organization.
- **Manageable Span of Control:** No supervisor oversees more than five to seven individuals or teams, ensuring effective monitoring under high stress.
- **Incident Action Planning:** Even during rapidly evolving events, establishing incident objectives ensures all agencies operate toward common goals.

2.2 NFPA 3000 as a Guiding Standard

National Fire Protection Association (NFPA) 3000 provides validated strategies for active shooter and hostile event response. Key tenets incorporated into URVI include Unified Command as a non-negotiable practice, integrated Rescue Task Forces entering warm zones under law enforcement protection, common operational language and compatible radio channels, and regular joint training exercises. By following NFPA 3000 guidance, URVI ensures Los Angeles County's practices meet nationally recognized benchmarks.

With this doctrinal foundation established, the framework next addresses how violent incidents are categorized—a distinction that directly shapes operational tempo, RTF deployment timing, and tactical approach.

3. INCIDENT TYPES: DYNAMIC VS. STATIC SCENARIOS

Not all violent incidents unfold the same way. URVI distinguishes between dynamic and static (or contained) scenarios because the operational tempo, phase transitions, RTF deployment, and tactical approach differ significantly between them. Recognizing static versus dynamic incidents is a critical skill for incident commanders.

3.1 Dynamic Incidents

A dynamic incident is one in which violence is actively occurring, or the threat is mobile and unpredictable. The defining characteristic is that the attacker is actively causing harm or has the immediate capacity to do so.

In dynamic incidents, the response tempo is at its highest. Phase 1 "Stop the Killing" dominates the early response. Law enforcement's priority is establishing Mobile Command and immediate engagement, with officers deploying toward the threat without delay. Mobile Command functions with the first officer on scene simultaneously fulfilling the incident command role while coordinating the rapid formation of Contact Teams to aggressively locate and neutralize the threat.

Phase 2 "Stop the Dying" hinges on RTF deployment. However, dynamic incidents carry a heightened risk of the situation reverting to Phase 1; for example, a contained shooter may break free.

Key operational considerations for dynamic incidents include solo officer engagement, which may be necessary before backup arrives; RTF deployment should begin as soon as any portion of the scene becomes a viable warm zone rather than waiting for full scene clearance. Communication must be continuous and concise given the fast-changing conditions. Unified Command formation occurs in parallel with tactical operations rather than sequentially.

3.2 Static or Contained Incidents

A static or contained incident is one where the threat is present but not actively causing harm.

In static incidents, the operational tempo is more deliberate. While Phase 1 principles still apply, the approach shifts from aggressive rapid deployment to containment, negotiation, and planned tactical intervention.

3.3 Transitioning Between Types

Incidents can shift between dynamic and static at any point. Incident commanders must continuously assess the nature of the threat and adjust the operational tempo accordingly. URVI's integrated command

structure, common terminology, and pre-planned procedures ensure that these transitions can be managed smoothly without losing coordination between agencies.

The three-phase response model described in the following section provides the operational structure that applies across both incident types, enabling smooth transitions regardless of how a scenario begins or evolves.

4. THREE-PHASE RESPONSE MODEL

The URVI guidelines organize the response to violent incidents into three distinct phases.

THE THREE-PHASE RESPONSE MODEL

Phase 1 – Stop the Killing: Law enforcement immediately engages to neutralize the threat. Speed and direct action are prioritized.

Phase 2 – Stop the Dying: Integrated Rescue Task Forces deploy into warm zones to treat and evacuate injured victims.

Phase 3 – Recovery and Transition: Scene secured, all critical victims addressed, shift to recovery and investigation.

Each phase has clear priorities and transitions based on conditions, not time. Phases may overlap, and responders must be prepared to revert to an earlier phase if conditions change.

4.1 Phase 1 – Stop the Killing

Phase 1 begins the moment a violent incident is recognized. The overriding mission is preventing further loss of life from the aggressor. Law enforcement officers immediately move to engage or contain the suspect. Fire and EMS resources stage in a safe area and prepare to activate rescue operations.

Law Enforcement Priorities

- **Establish Command and Rapidly Deploy to the Threat:** Officers deploy immediately to confront the suspect. Speed and direct action are prioritized to make contact with the threat as quickly as possible.
- **Neutralize and/or Isolate the Threat(s):** Use necessary force to stop the threat or work to isolate and contain the suspect to deny access to additional victims.
- **Protect Life:** Direct able-bodied individuals to evacuate or shelter in place as law enforcement moves to engage the threat.
- **Communicate Critical Information:** Relay suspect description, location, weapons, number of assailants, and additional assignments to dispatch and incoming units.
- **Establish Initial Perimeter:** Contain the incident geographically to prevent suspect escape and channel individuals away from danger.

Solo Officer Engagement

The first officer on scene must act without delay if lives are at risk, even without backup. Solo engagement is warranted when there is active gunfire or assault in progress, an immediate threat to multiple victims, and no other units are immediately available. Solo officers establish Mobile Command

and move toward the threat, broadcasting their location and actions to incoming units. Solo engagement is a stopgap until reinforcements arrive.

Contact Team Deployment

As additional officers arrive, they organize into contact teams of two to four officers who move together in coordinated tactical formation. The team lead guides movement toward the threat. Contact teams move dynamically, bypassing rooms to reach and neutralize the active threat quickly. Once the suspect is stopped, contact teams may pivot to searching for additional threats and directing Rescue Teams to victim locations.

Maintaining Command During Tactical Entry

Tactical urgency must not eclipse command and control. Once a field supervisor arrives, that supervisor should assume command rather than joining the entry team. The supervisor establishes a command post, organizes additional arriving units, manages communications, and coordinates with incoming agencies. Not every law enforcement officer should self-deploy into the building; the Incident Commander (IC) exercises discipline over responding units, directing them to perimeter, staging, or specific tactical assignments.

Supervisor Responsibilities

- **Establish Command and an Incident Command Post (ICP):** Assume the incident commander role and announce it over radio.
- **Request Additional Resources Early:** Additional field personnel, Fire/EMS, mutual aid, and Specialized Units.
- **Designate Staging Areas and Perimeters:** Direct incoming responders to a staging area away from the hot zone. Establish inner and outer perimeters. Keep emergency response vehicle access routes open.
- **Integrate Fire/EMS as They Arrive:** Physically meet the ranking fire officer, share situation updates, and form Unified Command.
- **Maintain Personnel Accountability:** Utilize departmental tools to track all assigned and staged incident resources.

4.2 Phase 2 – Stop the Dying

With the threat neutralized or contained, Phase 2 focuses on rapid medical intervention. Integrated police-fire/EMS Rescue Task Forces deploy into warm zones to treat injured victims using the MARCH (Massive Hemorrhage, Airway, Respiration, Circulation, Hypothermia/Head Injury) algorithm and evacuate them to safety. This phase represents a fundamental shift from the old paradigm of holding EMS back until scenes were fully cleared.

Considerations for RTF Deployment

- **Established Warm Zone:** Law enforcement has declared specific areas clear of active threats.
- **Force Protection Available:** Dedicated law enforcement officers are assigned to provide force protection for each RTF.
- **RTF Team Equipped:** Personnel identified, wearing ballistic protective equipment, carrying hemorrhage control and rapid patient movement equipment.
- **Communications Plan:** Clear radio channel established for RTF teams.

- **Secure Ingress/Egress Route:** Law enforcement has identified and physically secured a path into and out of the warm zone.

Operational Zone Definitions

OPERATIONAL ZONE DEFINITIONS

Hot Zone: Area of active or highly suspected threat. Only law enforcement operates here. Fire/EMS do not enter under any circumstances.

Warm Zone: Areas cleared by law enforcement but not fully secured. RTFs operate here with law enforcement force protection. All personnel wear ballistic protection. If security changes, the zone instantly becomes hot and RTFs withdraw.

Cold Zone: Safe area with no significant risk. Command posts, staging areas, and medical treatment and transport areas are located here.

Personnel must stay in their assigned zones at all times. If unsure whether an area is hot or warm, treat it as hot until confirmed otherwise.

RTF Functions

- **Rapid Casualty Location and Assessment:** Move through assigned sectors locating all victims. Direct walking wounded to self-evacuate to the cold zone.
- **Immediate Life-Saving Interventions:** Apply tourniquets, pack and dress gunshot wounds, seal open chest wounds, protect airways. Focus on hemorrhage control as the top medical priority.
- **Rapid Extraction to Casualty Collection Points:** Stabilize enough to move, then evacuate. The mantra is "treat and move." Warm-zone care takes under two minutes per patient; detailed treatment happens in the cold zone.
- **Continuous Triage and Handoff:** Flag/Tag patients by severity. Provide brief handoff reports to receiving personnel at the casualty collection point.

Tactical Emergency Medical Priorities

Medical operations in Phase 2 follow tactical emergency care principles. Priorities follow the M.A.R.C.H. components of the MARCH algorithm: massive hemorrhage control (tourniquets, wound packing, pressure dressings), airway and respiration management (jaw-thrust, chest seals, needle decompression for tension pneumothorax), rapid triage, extraction to a treatment area, and transport to definitive care.

Coordinating Medical and Security Operations

At the command level, the law enforcement and fire/EMS commanders jointly decide how many RTFs to deploy and where, prioritize search areas, and manage the pace of operations. Once a Rescue Group is established, the Rescue Group Supervisor (RGS) will manage all RTFs. A fire officer may be the formal RGS, but a designated law enforcement counterpart should coordinate closely with the RGS, or vice versa. Ideally, the two supervisors are co-located and standing side by side, with one focusing on victim care and the other on security.

4.3 Phase 3 – Recovery and Transition

Phase 3 begins when the immediate threat has been neutralized and all known critical victims have been addressed. The Incident Commander declares the shift from emergency response to recovery and scene management.

Command Priorities

- **Ensure Scene Security and Integrity:** Maintain perimeters for both security and evidence preservation. Restrict access to essential personnel.
- **Care for the Injured and Affected:** Confirm no additional victims remain untreated. Establish survivor assembly and family reunification areas. Deploy crisis counseling resources.
- **Public Information Management:** Activate a Joint Information Center. Issue one unified message from all agencies. Control rumors.
- **Assign Detectives to Identify All Transported Patients:** Ensure positive identification of every patient transported from the scene to hospitals. This is critical for family notification and investigative accountability.
- **Resource Management and Relief:** Rotate fresh personnel in. Establish rehab areas. Plan for sustained operations including shift coverage, lighting, and logistics.

The effective execution of all three phases depends on sound command procedures—beginning the moment the first responder arrives on scene, as described in the following section.

5. COMMAND PROCEDURES

5.1 First Officer on Scene

The first arriving responder has both the authority and responsibility to establish command, regardless of discipline or rank. This is a core ICS principle: someone must start organizing the response immediately. Waiting for a higher-ranking officer could lead to dangerous delays.

Responsibilities

- Establish and announce Mobile Command using a clear incident name (e.g., Main Street Command), and engage the immediate threat if lives are at risk. Perform a rapid size-up: nature of incident, exact location, suspect information, victim estimates, immediate hazards, available cover, initial resource needs, and zone designations.
- Communicate situational updates to dispatch and incoming responders using plain language.
- Establish initial control measures: identify hot, warm, and cold zones; set inner perimeter; identify safe approach routes and staging areas.
- Request additional resources.
- Organize incoming units with specific task assignments.
- Maintain command until formally relieved.

Initial Radio Communication

The first radio broadcast should be concise and accomplish multiple tasks: identify the officer on scene, describe the incident, name the command, and give initial directions. Example: "Lincoln 3 on scene - active shooter at the school, multiple victims in the lobby. I am establishing Central School Command.

Suspect last seen heading north hallway. Need additional units for perimeter north side. Fire and EMS stage at Maple and 1st." All communications use plain language, no agency-specific codes.

5.2 Mobile Command

Mobile command is the practice of the first arriving officer serving as incident commander while still directly engaged in the unfolding incident. This is doctrinally legitimate and expected. ICS and NIMS demand that command be established immediately—they do not require the first Incident Commander to be at a stationary command post. Mobile command bridges the gap between incident onset and the establishment of a formal command structure.

5.3 Role of Second Supervisor

When a second supervisor arrives, they should typically assume the Incident Commander role, freeing the first supervisor or officer to focus on tactical operations. The second supervisor's arrival creates a critical division of labor: one leader manages the tactical fight, the other coordinates the overall incident.

5.4 Transfer of Command

Command transfers follow a structured protocol to maintain continuity:

- The incoming commander reports to the current IC and receives a situation briefing covering: incident status, actions taken, resources deployed, safety concerns, and communications plan.
- The incoming commander explicitly accepts command.
- A clear radio announcement informs all personnel of the change (e.g., "All units, be advised: Lieutenant Smith now has Command").
- The outgoing commander transitions to a subordinate role, preserving their situational knowledge within the operation.
- When command transfers, the new commander should identify themselves by position or call sign (e.g., "Staff 3") so all units know who is directing the incident.

There must be no gap in leadership. The outgoing IC remains in command until the incoming commander explicitly states they have it. Multiple transfers may occur during an incident—from mobile to a fixed command post to an investigative command—and this complexity should be anticipated and practiced.

5.5 Transition from Mobile to Fixed Command Post

When conditions allow—threat level reduced, multi-agency personnel present, sufficient command staff available—command transitions to a fixed location in the cold zone. The fixed location should have strong radio reception, adequate space for unified leadership, and be clearly identified for incoming units.

The transition to a fixed command post marks the natural point at which multi-agency Unified Command is fully established—the structure described in the following section.

6. UNIFIED COMMAND

6.1 Purpose and Importance

Unified Command is the cornerstone of URVI. It ensures that law enforcement, fire, EMS, and other relevant agencies jointly manage the incident under one coherent plan. No single agency can handle all aspects of a major violent incident alone. Unified Command prevents confusion and delays, ensures threat

containment and medical care happen simultaneously, and improves responder safety through coordinated action.

6.2 Triggers for Formation

Unified Command should be established the moment two or more agencies are actively engaged.

6.3 Unified Command Responsibilities

- Establish overall incident objectives and priorities. Law enforcement should lead but must integrate medical resources seamlessly. Priority sequence: eliminate the threat, ensure security and stabilization, provide medical care, preserve evidence.
- Develop and implement a shared Incident Action Plan.
- Assign roles and tasks across agencies, leveraging each discipline's expertise.
- Manage resources and maintain situational awareness by gathering input from all disciplines.
- Ensure responder safety: evaluate risks, designate zones, mandate protective equipment.
- Coordinate phase transitions and handoffs to investigative or recovery authorities.
- Face-to-face coordination among unified commanders for critical decisions.

6.4 Command Post Setup

The Unified Command Post should be in the cold zone, clearly identified, accessible to all agencies, and equipped with reliable communications. In the earliest moments, this may be two vehicles parked next to each other—what matters is that all key leaders are physically together, making joint decisions. Co-location is the guiding principle. As resources arrive, the command post can expand to a dedicated vehicle or indoor space.

6.5 Communication Protocols

- A designated command radio channel monitored by all agencies' leadership.
- Integrated dispatch communication linking police, fire, and EMS dispatch centers.
- Plain language at all times—no agency-specific codes or jargon.
- Regular unified briefings to maintain alignment.
- One unified voice to the field: messages are agreed upon and not contradictory.

A communications plan is critical to operational success and should be established as one of the first Unified Command actions.

6.6 Preventing Conflict in Multi-Agency Command

Conflict is prevented through the establishment of unified objectives, clear division of labor under one plan, strong communication discipline, and a cooperative leadership ethos. When disagreements arise, unified commanders resolve them privately through discussion, then present a unified decision to the field. Pre-incident planning, joint training exercises, and established mutual aid agreements remove much of the ambiguity that breeds conflict during operations.

Among Unified Command's most critical operational responsibilities during Phase 2 is the deployment and management of Rescue Task Forces—the integrated police-fire/EMS teams described in the following section.

7. RESCUE TASK FORCES (RTFS)

7.1 Definition and Composition

A Rescue Task Force is a unified team of fire/EMS personnel and law enforcement officers formed to rapidly treat and extract victims in the warm zone. Standard composition pairs two to four firefighter/EMS members with at least two law enforcement officers providing force protection. Each RTF operates as a single cohesive unit with a unique designator (e.g., "RTF-1") and a single team leader.

The medical members handle casualty care while law enforcement officers provide 360-degree force protection, lead movement, and control the team's tempo. RTF members carry modified medical kits focused on hemorrhage control and airway management—lightweight and agile for rapid movement.

7.2 RTF Formation

RTFs are assembled in real time as units arrive on scene, under Unified Command direction. Once warm zones are identified and sufficient force protection is available, command pairs law enforcement officers with fire/EMS crews. Each RTF should ideally receive a clear assignment, insertion point, and communication channel. Pre-planned interoperability — common training, compatible radios, and interagency trust — is essential for rapid assembly.

7.3 Roles Within the RTF

Law enforcement officers serve as the protective overwatch. They lead movement, secure corridors and doorways, maintain 360-degree force protection around fire/EMS personnel, and control the pace. Officers do not separate from the RTF or pursue independent actions. Their sole mission is RTF team safety.

Fire/EMS personnel focus on medical operations: rapid assessment, life-saving interventions (following the MARCH algorithm, e.g., tourniquets, wound packing, chest seals, airway management), triage decisions, and patient evacuation. They operate under the tactical parameters set by law enforcement; if officers say a location is not secure, fire/EMS personnel adapt accordingly.

7.4 Deployment Triggers and Priorities

RTF deployment requires a designated warm zone, sufficient force protection, and appropriately equipped RTF teams (URVI personal protective equipment (PPE): ballistic helmet, Level 3 ballistic vest with plate, and no turnout gear). If resources are limited, command deploys to where immediate intervention will save the most lives and assigns subsequent teams as they become available.

7.5 Operational Cohesion

RTF members move together and stay together at all times. The team does not split up. Law enforcement and fire/EMS maintain visual contact throughout operations. Every movement is communicated and acknowledged within the team. If one member pauses (treating a patient or reloading), the entire team pauses. Anyone on the team should speak up to improve communications or voice safety concerns—this is encouraged and expected.

7.6 RTF-to-Command Communication

- Each RTF uses a designated call sign (e.g., RTF 1, RTF 2, etc.) and communicates with command on the specified channel.

- Regular status reports: area cleared, patient count, supply needs, team status.
- Emergency calls use plain language for immediate threat situations.
- Medical information relay: number and severity of patients, resource needs.
- All orders from command are acknowledged by RTF leaders.

7.7 Withdrawal Criteria

RTFs withdraw when conditions deteriorate beyond acceptable risk:

- The warm zone becomes hot (active threat re-emerges in the RTF's area).
- Loss of communications with command or law enforcement overwatch.
- Team member injury requiring immediate evacuation.
- Explicit command order (e.g., tactical operation about to commence in the area). All RTF members are trained to react immediately to withdrawal orders.

7.8 Multiple RTF Oversight

For large incidents with multiple RTFs, a Rescue Group Supervisor is assigned to maintain accountability for all RTFs. Command deconflicts RTF operations with ongoing tactical operations to ensure rescue and tactical efforts complement rather than endanger each other.

The effectiveness of RTF operations—and of all incident coordination—depends on reliable, disciplined communications across all agencies, as addressed in the following section.

8. COMMUNICATIONS AND INTEROPERABILITY

8.1 Communications Principles

Effective communication is the foundation of unified response and requires plain language at all times during violent incident operations—no ten-codes, no agency-specific jargon. All responders must understand every message transmitted. Common terminology for zones (hot, warm, cold), teams (contact team, RTF), and roles (Incident Commander, Operations, Contact Group Supervisor, Rescue Group Supervisor, Staging) is standardized across disciplines.

8.2 Radio Channel Architecture

Unified Command establishes a communications plan as one of its first actions. This typically includes a command channel for leadership coordination and a tactical channel for field operations. If interoperable frequencies are not available, supervisory personnel may share portable radios to bridge the communication gap.

8.3 Not All Agencies Can Communicate Directly

The framework acknowledges that not all law enforcement agencies can communicate directly with fire departments due to incompatible radio systems. Planning should account for this limitation through pre-designated interoperable channels, relay procedures, face-to-face communication at co-located command posts, and liaison officers who bridge the communications gap.

8.4 Information Flow During Operations

Critical information must flow in both directions between field teams and Unified Command. Field teams report: threat status, victim locations and counts, areas cleared, hazards encountered, and resource needs. Command pushes: zone status updates, tactical operation warnings, phase transitions, and resource deployments. Information flow should be continuous but disciplined—every transmission should be short, necessary, and actionable. Over-communication of important safety information is preferred over assumptions.

8.5 Subsequent Control Measures

As the incident evolves, command must communicate updated control measures to all units. This includes changes to zone boundaries (e.g., "Floor 1 is now cold, Floor 2 warm, Floor 3 hot"), updated staging locations, modified ingress/egress routes, and shifts in tactical focus. Each update is broadcast clearly and acknowledged by affected units.

The communications discipline described in this section does not emerge spontaneously in the field—it is built through the joint training and preparedness activities detailed in the following section.

9. TRAINING AND PREPAREDNESS

9.1 Joint Training Imperative

Successful unified response is largely the product of groundwork laid before an incident. Agencies must invest in regular multi-agency training and exercises. Tabletop exercises allow commanders to practice unified decision-making. Full-scale drills simulate real incidents with mock Unified Command Posts, RTF deployments, and communication under stress. These exercises build personal relationships and trust across agencies, surface radio incompatibilities or terminology confusion, and create organizational muscle memory.

9.2 Training for Phase 2 Operations

Phase 2 operations—RTF deployment, warm zone medical care, and integrated police-fire tactical movement—require dedicated training emphasis. Fire/EMS personnel must be proficient in Tactical Emergency Casualty Care (TECC), comfortable operating in ballistic protective equipment, and practiced in moving with law enforcement force protection. Law enforcement must be trained in force protection tactics, close coordination with non-law personnel, and basic hemorrhage control. Joint RTF drills are essential for building the cross-discipline coordination that saves lives.

9.3 First-On-Scene Leadership Training

Patrol officers and junior supervisors must be placed into simulated critical incidents where they practice being the initial incident commander. This includes rapid size-up, command declaration, initial unit assignments, and command transfer. Agencies should provide job aids and checklists, reinforce plain language radio communication, and create a culture where taking initiative is expected and supported.

9.4 Pre-Incident Planning

Agencies should jointly develop protocols for Unified Command formation, including pre-designated command post locations for high-risk venues, interoperable radio channels, and information-sharing

procedures. Pre-incident planning also includes maintaining contact directories, agreeing on mutual aid triggers, and identifying liaison officers for interdisciplinary deployment.

9.5 Empowerment and Support

Training must be paired with organizational empowerment. Agency leadership should clearly communicate that first-on-scene command decisions are expected and supported. Officers who take command and make reasonable decisions under extreme stress should not face unfair second-guessing. This culture of empowerment frees responders to act decisively. Post-incident reviews should specifically examine whether first responders established command and organized the response—and if not, identify training gaps. Clear policy directives establishing the authority of first arriving personnel protect both the individual responder and the agency.

9.6 Sample Size-Up Components

Agencies should train first responders to rapidly assess and communicate the following during initial size-up:

- Nature of incident (active shooter, hostage situation, bombing, etc.) and current dynamics.
- Exact location and scope of affected area.
- Suspect information: number, description, weapons, last known location and direction of movement.
- Victim and casualty estimates.
- Immediate threats and hazards beyond the primary suspect (secondary devices, fire, hazmat).
- Available cover, terrain, entry and exit points.
- Initial resource needs and requested assets.
- Preliminary zone designations and perimeter recommendations.

Training with sample size-up scenarios—including verbal practice under simulated stress—builds the muscle memory that enables rapid, accurate communication during real events.

Even the best-trained agencies must manage the practical challenges of multi-jurisdictional resource coordination when a major incident draws units from across the county—the subject of the following section.

10. MUTUAL AID AND RESOURCE MANAGEMENT

10.1 Managing Incoming Resources

In the early phase of a critical incident, resources often arrive rapidly from across the county. The Incident Commander must manage this influx to prevent chaos. The first priority is establishing a staging area in the cold zone where incoming units report and await assignment. Without direction, uncontrolled convergence can lead to crossfire incidents, traffic gridlock, or dilution of effort. The IC will assign arriving or staged units to critical tasks: forming additional contact teams, staffing perimeter positions, securing staging areas, or preparing for RTF deployment. Effective resource management means preventing overcommitment—not every arriving officer should rush inside. Some are better used for perimeter security, traffic control, or staging management. The IC must continuously evaluate priorities and distribute personnel accordingly.

10.2 Mutual Aid Integration

Los Angeles County's multi-jurisdictional landscape means that significant violent incidents will draw resources from multiple agencies. Mutual aid units arriving from other jurisdictions must be seamlessly integrated into the existing Incident Command System structure. They report to staging, receive assignments from the IC, and operate under the unified plan. Pre-established mutual aid agreements and common training in ICS/NIMS principles make this integration possible.

Mutual aid personnel should receive a quick briefing upon arrival covering: incident status, current command structure, radio channels in use, and their specific assignment. The goal is to get them operational quickly without disrupting the existing organization. A staging area manager logs all arriving mutual aid units and their capabilities.

10.3 Resource Tracking

Unified Command maintains accountability of all resources through continuous tracking. This includes knowing which units are deployed and where, which are in staging awaiting assignment, and which have been released. Resource tracking ensures that if conditions change, command can rapidly reassign or recall units. It also provides essential data for after-action review.

10.4 Preventing Freelancing/Self-deployment and Overlap

A persistent challenge in large incidents is preventing freelancing—individual responders or units taking independent action outside the incident command structure. Freelancing/self-deployment compromises accountability, creates safety risks, and can undermine the unified plan. The framework addresses this through clear command structure, mandatory check-in at staging, specific task assignments for all arriving units, and a culture of discipline reinforced through training. Every responder operates under the incident organization, following the direction of their assigned supervisor.

The quick-reference checklists in the following section consolidate the key decision points and responsibilities from Sections 4 through 10 into an actionable format for use in the field.

11. OPERATIONAL QUICK-REFERENCE

11.1 First Officer on Scene Checklist

- ☐ Announce arrival and establish command: "[Unit] on scene, establishing [Location] Command."
- ☐ Identify and broadcast: incident type, suspect description, weapons, location, direction of movement.
- ☐ If active threat: move toward threat to engage or contain. If threat contained: begin organizing.
- ☐ Designate hot/warm/cold zones (even if preliminary).
- ☐ Request additional resources.
- ☐ Identify staging area for incoming units.
- ☐ Assign arriving units to specific tasks: contact teams, perimeter, staging.
- ☐ Maintain command until formally relieved by a higher authority.

11.2 Supervisor Arrival Checklist

- ☐ Announce assumption of command or confirm existing IC.
- ☐ Receive briefing from initial IC: threat status, resources deployed, victims, hazards.

- ☐ Establish or confirm fixed command post location in cold zone.
- ☐ Verify perimeter positions and staging area.
- ☐ Contact fire/EMS commander to establish Unified Command.
- ☐ Ensure communications plan is in place (shared channels, plain language).
- ☐ Begin tracking resources and assignments.
- ☐ Plan for Phase 2 transition: RTF readiness, warm zone identification.

11.3 Unified Command Formation Checklist

- ☐ Law enforcement and fire/EMS commanders physically co-located.
- ☐ Joint situation briefing completed.
- ☐ Common objectives established (eliminate threat, secure and stabilize, provide medical care).
- ☐ Incident Action Plan (even verbal) agreed upon.
- ☐ Communications plan established: command channel, tactical channel, RTF channel.
- ☐ Roles assigned: Operations, Contact Team Group, Rescue Group, Medical Group, Staging, Safety.
- ☐ Radio announcement: "Unified Command established at [location] with [agencies]."

11.4 RTF Deployment Checklist

- ☐ Warm zone confirmed by law enforcement.
- ☐ RTF teams (fire/EMS and law enforcement force protection officers) briefed and assigned.
- ☐ Fire/EMS members equipped: ballistic vest, helmet, trauma kit.
- ☐ Communications tested: radio check with command.
- ☐ Once identified, the insertion point and route are briefed to all team members.
- ☐ Extraction route identified.
- ☐ RTF designator assigned (e.g., RTF-1).
- ☐ Team moves as a single unit—no separation.

11.5 Phase Transition Decision Points

PHASE 1 → PHASE 2:

- ☐ Suspect neutralized, contained, or isolated from potential victims.
- ☐ At least partial warm zone established.
- ☐ RTFs formed and ready.
- ☐ Unified Command concurrence achieved.

PHASE 2 → PHASE 3:

- ☐ All known critical victims evacuated.
- ☐ No active threats confirmed.
- ☐ Scene security established for recovery operations.
- ☐ Investigative and recovery personnel arriving.

For the full definitions of key terms used throughout this framework, refer to the Key Definitions section below.

12. KEY DEFINITIONS

Active Assailant: An individual or individuals actively engaged in killing or attempting to kill people in a populated area, typically using firearms but potentially using any weapon.

Casualty Collection Point (CCP): A designated safe area (typically in the cold zone) where victims are brought for further triage, treatment, and preparation for ambulance transport.

Cold Zone: The safe area surrounding an incident, free of active threat, where command posts, staging, and medical treatment areas are established.

Contact Team: A small group of law enforcement officers (typically 2–4) who move together to locate and neutralize an active threat.

Force Protection: Law enforcement officers assigned to provide armed security for fire/EMS personnel operating in warm zones.

Hot Zone: The area of active or suspected threat where only law enforcement operates. Fire/EMS do not enter.

Incident Command System (ICS): A standardized, scalable organizational structure for managing incidents, providing clear chain of command and modular functions.

Mobile Command: The practice of the first arriving officer serving as incident commander while still engaged in the unfolding incident, prior to establishing a fixed command post.

NFPA 3000: The National Fire Protection Association standard for active shooter/hostile event response programs, establishing best practices for unified response.

NIMS: The National Incident Management System, providing principles for multi-agency coordination including common terminology, unified command, and resource management.

Rescue Group Supervisor (RGS): The leader assigned to coordinate the deployment, operations, and accountability of all Rescue Task Forces during an incident. Typically a fire officer, with a designated law enforcement counterpart for close coordination; both supervisors are ideally co-located, with one focusing on victim care and the other on security.

Rescue Task Force (RTF): A unified team of fire/EMS personnel and law enforcement officers formed to treat and evacuate victims in warm zones under armed protection.

Rescue Team(s): Law enforcement resources whose mission it is to enter the Hot Zone to rescue victims. They are configured to search for and extract the injured from the Hot Zone to the Warm Zone, a CCP, or the Treatment Area/Cold Zone.

TECC (Tactical Emergency Casualty Care): Civilian adaptation of military combat casualty care principles, guiding medical treatment in high-threat environments with phases for direct threat, indirect threat, and evacuation care.

THREAT Protocol: Response model from the Hartford Consensus: Threat suppression, Hemorrhage control, Rapid Extrication, Assessment, and Transport.

Unified Command: A leadership structure where commanders from multiple agencies jointly manage an incident, sharing authority, setting common objectives, and developing a single action plan.

Warm Zone: An area cleared by law enforcement but not fully secured, where RTFs operate under armed escort. Personnel wear ballistic protective equipment and remain prepared for rapid withdrawal.

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FIGURE 1: EXAMPLE BASIC URVI ORGANIZATION

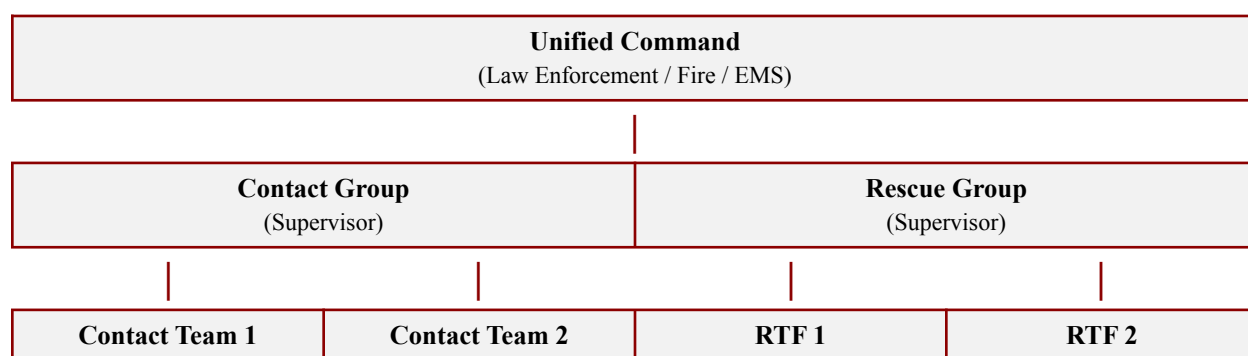


Figure 1: Example basic organizational structure for a URVI incident response, showing the two-branch command hierarchy under Unified Command. Law enforcement Contact Groups manage threat neutralization; Rescue Groups coordinate RTF medical and extraction operations. Structure expands or contracts based on incident conditions, available resources, and Unified Command direction.